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About the Author

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Preface

Chapter 1: Unexpected Encounters

Scarlett's POV

His gaze is enough to light every particle of my skin on fire, his piercing blue eyes a mesmerizing reminder of the stars that light the dark sky.

His chiseled jaw, and the tattoo that runs down the side of his neck to his muscular back, broad and defined. The dark hair he keeps slicked back, with just a few stray strands falling over his forehead.

There's so much more to him than meets the eye–so much more under this brooding, dangerous facade. And I want to know all of it.

"Mia bella," his whisper falls against my ear. "You're so beautiful." He moves his hands to the waistband of my pants, tugging on it.

I place my hand over his shoulder, his muscles tensing under my touch. "Who are you," I narrow my eyes, trying to find the source that makes me feel pulled to him.

His gaze remains on me, all consuming, and his fingers now caress my face, leaving a trail of desire in their wake.

There's a danger in his eyes, a darkness that I want to delve into, and I should be scared, but my curiosity gets the best of me.

Who is he, and why does he make me feel so good, so ignited?

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Deleted[Guest User]: *I can feel his hands all over me, run*

Deleted[Guest User]: *want this?*

Deleted[Guest User]: *past*

Deleted[Guest User]: *into*

Deleted[Guest User]: *my white, lacy panties. His fingers f*

Deleted[Guest User]:

Deleted[Guest User]:

Deleted[Guest User]: *as he holds me up against the wall*

Deleted[Guest User]:

Deleted[Guest User]: *The things I want to do to you,You'r*

Deleted[Guest User]: *h*

Deleted[Guest User]: *deep*

Deleted[Guest User]: *voice*

Deleted[Guest User]: *that word he has reserved just for m*

Deleted[Guest User]:

Deleted[Guest User]: *them*

Deleted[Guest User]: *aroused*

"Stay still." His voice is deep, commanding.

"Tell me who you are."

"Stay still."

Suddenly, I sense his tone change to something darker, something more sinister, leaving me confused.

I try to move, but he holds me down, "I said, stay still."

My eyes open, and I bring them over to his face, a grin playing on his lips.

"Dante."

I feel myself come to my senses, my eyes widening as he stands next to my bed. I can feel my heart racing, sweat dripping down my forehead.

What is he doing here? Am I dreaming? Or is this real?

Before I can say a word, he breaks the silence, the same grin spread across his mouth. "Hello, Scarlett."

Oh, this is real.

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"Mm, that's my good girl. Stand still for me, baby."

He moves two fingers into my hole, pounding me as my walls clench around them, his thumb on my clit, the orgasm inching closer.

"Oh god, I'm so close."

"

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"Take my name."

I fist his hair, bringing his ear to my mouth, "Dante," the word leaves my mouth in a breathless whisper.

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The quiet here feels nice - eerie, but safe. I stand in the doorway of my new, little home away from all the chaos enjoying the soft creaking sound of the wooden floors and watching the trees sway in the morning breeze.

This is what I've always wanted.

I close the door behind me and walk inside. The house itself isn't very big, but it's enough for one person, and that's all I need. Dark wooden floors extend throughout, with white walls and an empty room waiting to be furnished.

Deleted[Guest User]: me, and

All that stands in this room is a sofa, a table and a few side tables, already brought in by my movers.

This is the first time in a long time I've felt this free. I can do whatever I want, and it's as if I'm twenty again, figuring myself out.

The town is small - a quaint little place in the nook of Connecticut. *Levicii Cove.*

There's a sense of community here, something that the city of New York was void of. It feels like an end to everything I've been running away from. All the chaos, the pain, the sabotage and politics.

I finally feel like I'm ready to work on what I've always wanted - my writing. I saved enough money to last me a while, and knowing this gives me peace - enough peace to do exactly what I want.

Writing has always been something I love, but there was no time between my corporate job and dealing with city life. Now, I feel the words flowing in. I can write so much, and my novels are my escape. I get to live a fantasy life through them, and I can't believe I almost let myself lose that.

I smile gently, holding my laptop in my arms, holding it against my chest.

I can finally be myself now.

There are so many things to do, and I can't waste another second. I tie my hair into a bun and walk back out, wearing a grey set of sweatshirt and pants, ready to unload the multiple boxes in the back of my car.

Suddenly, I hear a voice. *Loud, haunting and captivating.*

I ignore it at first, but something within me triggers my curiosity and I stop moving, setting down the box.

My eyes land on a man - tall, dressed in a suit, and thick hair that's been slicked back, allowing only two pieces of hair to fall onto his forehead.

There's something dark about him - his black hair, broad shoulders and muscular body, and the intensity in his eyes. I freeze, but that man doesn't even notice me.

Until, he does.

"Need something?" he looks at me. His tone is low, his voice deep and gruff, as if he's mad just seeing me here.

"Uh, no. I'm good. Thank you." I smile softly, picking up the box again and tightening my grip on it.

He looks at me - *rather stares* - for a few moments, his eyes scanning my face, as if to memorize every inch of it.

"Right." He looks down and begins walking away.

Weirdo.

Hot weirdo.

I roll my eyes at him and begin working on decorating my space. I take out my tools, and start drilling holes into the wall, putting in screws to hang my art.

But, no matter what I do, I can't help but think about that man.

Who was he?

And who shoved a stick up his ass?

Deleted[Guest User]: *Why was he so mad?*

Deleted[Guest User]: *W*

And why did he stare at me like that?

I scoff at myself - at my inability to let things go.

I can't deny it, but there's something about him that makes me feel pulled to him. I can still feel his gaze lingering over me, the air getting heavier and my heart racing faster.

I sit down, dust my jeans, and think about our encounter. His presence was too powerful—almost dominating—and something tells me I should stay away from him.

But, with an appearance like his, a girl's got to wonder what he's doing in this small town. I mean, its basically a town for the old, or for people like me, running away from city life.

So, what is he running from?

I keep telling myself I'm uninterested, but I can't help imagining things.

Things he would do to me, to my body. The pleasure he'd make me feel.

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I creep up to my window and stare at his house - one that's twice the size of mine.

I wonder what a single man needs such a big house for. I mean, what does he even do?

I don't care, I whisper to myself.

But I know that's a lie. There's more in his eyes, and I need to find out what.

I continue enjoying my new home. I've decorated the place with ornaments and things that make me feel more at home. As the sun begins to set, I take my laptop outside and sit in my backyard where I set up my little garden with chairs and a table.

I try to focus on what I'm writing, but something keeps distracting me. I hear voices - tense voices. I look to the side, and there he is, standing on his porch.

The same man from before. He's standing just beyond the bushes with his back turned towards me, talking to someone on the phone.

"Dante," a man's voice calls out to him, and he turns around, raising a hand, gesturing to him to wait.

Dante.

My brooding, dangerously handsome, next-door neighbor.

He seems tense and I don't understand what he's talking about, but something about his tone grabs my attention. "I'm telling you. You better keep quiet; nobody should know about it."

My heart skips a beat, and I get up from my chair. I don't mean to hear the conversation, but now that I have, I'm too curious not to.

I walk over to the rose bushes in my garden, peering through them, straight into his house where he's standing.

"I don't care. Find him, and keep him alive. I want to watch him beg for his life as I drain him of it." He grits out, shutting the phone and throwing it to the side.

I feel my blood run cold, my body paralyze with fear.

Did he just say he's going to kill a man…

I take a step back, overwhelmed by what I've just heard. I don't realize it, but I step on a branch that cracks under my weight, making enough of a sound to grab his attention. Dante's attention.

I glance up at the porch, and he's facing me now. His gaze burns through my skin, full of a fiery rage.

"Fuck." I whisper to myself.

I begin slowly taking steps back, his gaze steady on mine. He puts his hands into his pockets, glaring at me, and before I know it, I'm running into my house. I shut the door to the backyard behind me, and lean against it, heaving.

I need to stay far, far away from him.

As I feel my breaths stabilize, I walk into my house, but as I take a step into the living room, I bump into something.

I look up, and it's him. His blue, piercing eyes and a tattoo running down his neck, some kind of symbol.

Dante.

"You should really keep your doors locked," he speaks in a low voice, looking down at me.

God, what have I gotten myself into?

Chapter 2: Uncovering Secrets

Dante's POV

I watch as her body stiffens with fear when she realizes I'm in her house.

I'd be lying if I said the effect I have on her doesn't make me feel good, because it does.

Not just because I scare her, but because the effect she has on me is indescribable, something I've never felt before. And it makes me feel weak.

Her hair is tied into a messy bun, a few light brown locks falling out of place. She has a beautiful face - full lips, eyes as green as the trees in a forest and a sweetness to her that I want to taste. Darken. Taint.

Only someone so stupid would try to get this close to me.

She doesn't look stupid to me, though. She looks…*mesmerising*.

But, she crossed a line, and I need to make sure that never happens again. If she knows as little as a grain of information about my business, it's going to be a serious problem.

Her eyes widen as I stand in front of her. She stands there like a statue, and I can see her contemplating all the possible ways she can escape.

I can also tell by the look on her face–she knows she can't.

"How did you get in," she looks past me, her body still.

"You enjoy the show?" My words are full of warning, rage swirling in my eyes. I step closer to her, and she simultaneously backs up, until her back hits a wall.

I can see her trembling and she doesn't answer. She's still.

Smart.

The last thing I want is someone to answer me back.

"I don't like people interfering in my business," I let out a low growl, leaning closer to her as I drop the weight of my words on her, "especially nosy neighbors who just moved into this neighborhood. Don't cross my path again. And, if you do –" I raise a brow.

"I…" she tries talking but I cut her off abruptly.

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"You nothing. You heard nothing, you saw nothing. And if I hear you telling anyone otherwise, count your days in this house," I grin at her–a sly, knowing grin.

She swallows the lump in her throat as tears start glazing her eyes. There is fear and uncertainty in her, but at the same time, I can feel her curiosity emanating. I should leave right now, but I decide to stand there,

waiting for her to speak. I need to know what she's thinking about because I don't want her to know jack about my business.

She shifts in a flash with determination.

Determination to escape.

Before I comprehend what she's doing, she jumps and swings her arm at me. She stops right in front of my face as my hand comes up to hold her fist. I barely flinch as her other hand makes it way, and before she knows it, I have control over both her hands, leaving no way for her to escape.

"Bad move." I whisper, roughly tightening my hold around her wrist, tight enough to disarm her before she throws another punch my way. I can feel her pulse under my hand, quickening with each passing moment.

She continues fighting, throwing herself around, trying to run away, but I'm not letting her go. I pull her against me, feeling her breath against mine. "You want to do this?" I mutter under my breath, pinning her against the wall with her hands above her head.

"Let me go." She fights against me, her body shaking out of fear. I notice something in her eyes, a rage. a dark energy that blends perfectly with mine, mirroring it.

"That's one thing about me." I smirk, "I don't let go." I loosen my grip slightly and bring her hands down.

Deleted[Guest User]: slightly, and

Before she can retaliate, I turn her around and pin her against the wall with her hands behind her back. With one hand, I remove her hair from her ear and begin whispering, “You’re not as tough as you think. Don’t test me again, otherwise you’re going to find yourself in positions you don’t want to be in.”

She starts fighting back, but I don’t let go of my grip, even as she begins yelling, “Help me! This man is going insane!”

“No one’s coming to save you. No one can hear you. So, stop screaming,” I groan, pressing her harder into the wall.

“Get off me,” she hisses, turning her head back to meet my eyes. “I didn’t hear anything, I swear!”

I scoff, “I’ll do as I please,” I lean forward towards her ear. “Be nice, bella. I don’t mind killing people I don’t like.”

She freezes as the words leave my mouth, “You’re a murderer. I knew it.”

Here we go again.

“I don’t think I care,” I grip her hands tightly.

“Let me go!” She wriggles her body under my hold.

I can keep her like this all night, but I step back, letting her go. She’s scared and tense, gasping for air and takes a few steps away from me.

"Don't you dare snoop around me again. I'm warning you." I look straight into her eyes, pinning her in place with a stare before walking away.

As I walk away, I feel like I'm losing grip of myself. I feel a coldness creeping in.

I stand outside her half open door, wondering if she heard everything, and I can't afford that. I replay the entire conversation in my mind and that's when I realize - she was too close. Right outside the porch where I was yelling.

And she probably heard everything.

Fuck…

I shouldn't have let her go.

I should've been more threatening. But, I can't risk drawing more attention. *Not now.*

One thing I know for sure, I'll have to keep an eye on her just enough to make sure she stays quiet. If she talks…

No, let's not go there. I don't want to go there. Because as much as I hate nosy people, she's gotten under my skin in a way that's very different. And, I find myself not wanting to hurt her.

I go back and sit on the sofa, trying to understand what just happened. Suddenly my phone rings, and I see that it's Marco, one of my men.

"Who was with you outside?" He speaks in a low tone.

"What do you mean?" I run my fingers through my hair, resting my forehead on my palm.

"Boss, we've got a problem." He speaks, hesitantly.

"Speak."

"They saw you in some girl's house, coming out." He whispers, as if someone's watching. "Boss, they think she's yours."

"What? That girl?" I feel like someone just punched me in the gut. "Ridiculous."

"They don't care about it. From what my guy told me, they're already planning on using her against you. Leverage," he mutters.

This can't be happening.

"How long do we have?" I stand up instantly.

"Not long."

My hands descends on the table, banging on it.

God, that girl is a target because of me.

"She doesn't even know. And we can't let her find out, or get kidnapped," I end the call.

I don't know why, but I find myself caring about her safety. If it were anyone else, I wouldn't blink an eye. I'd let my enemies do as they please, keep the target off my back.

I find my heart fighting with my own mind – choosing between either protecting her, or putting myself at risk. With each passing moment, I find myself more and more inclined to save her, to be her protector.

I should let this go. But, I can't.

That beautiful face, and those soft eyes. They weren't made for the harsh, mafia world.

No, they were made to feel love.

I don't know how much time I have but I can't let them get her first. I spend the next few hours thinking about what to do. I fear going to sleep tonight. If they use her–they'll hurt her.

I know what I have to do.

I have to keep her away from the world. Kidnap her. I need to get to her first.

I look into her house through my window and see her lights go out, hinting to me that she's in there and going to bed. It's late at night, and there's no time better than this.

I wait an hour before I enter her house and walk to her bedroom. The night is awfully quiet and I sneak my way in, knowing her lock is still broken from the last time I got in.

I stand there, watching her sleep under the moonlight, and as if her body knows, her eyes open. "Dante."

"Hello, Scarlett," I place my hand over her mouth. "Don't make a sound, bella."

Before she can say a word, I bring the cloth soaked in chloroform to her mouth.

"Everything's going to be just fine."

Chapter 3: The Captor and His Captive

Scarlett's POV

I suddenly wake up, my heart pounding. I feel suffocated. My hands are tied, and the rope cuts into my skin. I scream, but I know nobody can hear me. There's something shoved in my mouth, pressing hard against my lips. I shake myself, but I can't let go of it.

I haven't recovered from what happened two nights ago and now this. I came here for a fresh start. This isn't the start I'm wished for. *Why are you doing this? I shouldn't have been involved.* I feel panicked. The ropes make me nervous.

I'm glad I don't have a blindfold on me. *I haven't done anything wrong.* I scan the room; my vision is blurry from sleeplessness and dizziness. I don't know, but fear has taken control of me.

I don't remember seeing this place before. *Where am I?* I finally regain my vision, and the room looks majestic. Something out of imagination. Heavy velvet curtains, wooden floor, and beautiful polished furniture. There's a big player behind it. I constantly wonder where I am.

I feel uneasy; it's hard for me to breathe.

Why did Dante do this to me? What does he want?

Suddenly, the door creaks open, and I freeze. I'm no longer fighting to escape. I hear footsteps approaching me. I'm too scared to even look in that direction.

Just kill me and finish this.

With ragged gasps, I realize they're coming closer in my direction.
"Please, don't hurt me."

I hold my breath, dreading what's about to happen next, and that's when I see him. Dante.

He stands right before me, watching how I'm fighting the ropes.

He's cold-hearted, and I can tell none of this bothers him. He's probably seen worse.

"I told you I didn't hear anything. Why are you doing this?" I sniffle.

I feel like I'm falling apart.

My teary eyes blur my vision, and I feel exhausted. "All I want is my peace. Don't do this. I'm telling you, I didn't hear anything." I struggle to talk as I beg for my freedom.

He doesn't flinch. Just stands there, staring at me. His arms crossed, he smirks, turning his back on me, making my blood boil. "I'm not cracking a joke here. I told you, I don't know anything."

But he says nothing.

How can one be so cold? What does someone have to go through to be this cold.

"I don't think I made it clear enough. But, I'm trying to protect you." He finally speaks, which sounds more like a growl.

"You're saying kidnapping me is going to keep me safe? Who even are you? And what the hell do you need to keep me safe from?" I scoff, shaking my head, "Protection?" Tears roll down my face. "Who are you trying to protect me from? Yourself?" I spit in his direction.

He faces me, silent, his eyes growing darker. The lack of answers makes me nervous, and I begin pulling the ropes again, "Help me. I'm stuck here." I yell.

He races towards me and puts his hand over my mouth, "You don't understand right now, but this is for your own good."

I shrink back, back to being vulnerable, as I feel his weight on me, knowing I can't do anything to fight against it. His voice sends chills down my spine, "If I didn't do this, you'd be in danger."

"Why me?" My voice is muffled under his hand.

"I can't tell you that. But, I'm not going to harm you. I'm just trying to keep you safe. Don't go against me." He looks straight into my eyes, "Do you understand?"

I shake my head, sobbing harder, "I don't trust you. You're a monster."

His face softens, as if these words comfort him. "You don't have to trust me, bella. Just don't do anything that can kill you. Stay where you're safe, stay with me."

Deleted[Guest User]: Stay in front of me at all times

As fear tightens its grip on my throat, I realize I can't let him know I'm scared. I need to be strong. I've done nothing wrong. Just because I got caught hearing him doesn't mean I'm under threat.

"My name is Scarlett! And you can't keep me tied up here forever," I snap at him, my voice louder than usual. "Do you think tying me up is going to make things easy? Well, you're wrong. I'm going to fight against you, Dante. I'm going to get out."

I frantically start shaking my body, attempting to break the chair I sit on.

He stands there, calm and composed, as if my temperament doesn't threaten him, as if he's waiting for me to wear out.

"You don't know what you're doing," he responds. "You're safer here."

I can sense his tone change into something sincere, more caring. *But, no.* He's probably just trying to manipulate me. I need to get out. I need to save myself.

"I don't care what you're doing. I need to leave. I don't want you to protect me. You're insane," I yell at him. "Being bound and gagged doesn't make me safe!"

"Shut up. You don't know what's happening," Dante yells back at me, his cool exterior finally breaking to reveal a flood of emotions, emotions he's been hiding.

I yank the ropes harder, but they just don't loosen up. "You don't get to choose. You don't own me. Find someone else who you can protect."

I scream at the top of my lungs, and he takes a step closer. I feel his presence dominating me, overpowering my whole being. I want to keep fighting, but something forces me not to. Something about his face threatens me to calm down, his cold gaze instantly shutting me up.

He leans over me, grabs the chair and jerks it. "You're making this harder. I don't want to own you. I'm here to protect you, and right now, you're making that fucking difficult!"

"Please," the words is full of desperation.

He rubs the back of his neck, releasing a deep sigh before untying me. "I don't want to keep you captive. I just need you safe."

"Finally." I begin rubbing my wrist in excruciating pain.

I glare at him and before either of us can say a word, I run towards the door. He grabs my hand and pulls me back, a calm, irritated expression on his face.

His reactions only fuel my anger, and I look around before spotting a gun on the table next to me and picking it up with my free hand.

It's his gun.

I point right at his chest, "I'll shoot you if you don't let me go."

He locks his eyes with mine and stands still, as if he knows with confidence that I won't pull the trigger.

"Go ahead." He responds, his voice steady. It's as if he's challenging me, "Pull the fucking trigger if you think it'll make things easy."

Why isn't he afraid?

I don't get it.

"If you need this to keep you safe, you can have it. You can keep the gun, but know this. I'm not going to harm you."

I hesitate, my pulse racing. *There's so much I'm curious about.*

I keep the gun pointed to his chest, ”Why won't you tell me the truth? What is it that you do?”

He shakes his head, “That’s none of your business.”

"You've already dragged me into this mess. I deserve to know." I argue back.

"What is wrong with you? I'm trying to keep you safe," he yells back.

“By kidnapping me? That doesn't make me safe. I want to know why you're doing this. What is it that’s putting you in this position,” I yell at his face.

"Fine." He bangs his hand on the table. He releases a deep breath, staring into my eyes. “You want to know? Well, I run a mafia. In fact, I lead it. This town you’ve come to–Levicii Cove. There’s nothing peaceful about it.” He sighs, bringing his hand to his hip, “My name is Dante Levicii. I run this town. I control everything that goes on here. My family founded it, and for decades, we’ve run our business through it. I was forced to come back because of some…issues, with a deal. And God, did you choose a bad time to enter my life,” he scoffs, as if everything he told me is normal, and I’m the insane one.

I freeze, “What? What do you mean mafia? How is this possible,” my eyes fall to the floor as the shock courses through me, the hand that was pointed at him with a gun now falling to my side.

"You asked for this, Scarlett. Now, you can do what you want–but you can't leave. Not without me. I need to keep you here to keep you alive."

Before I can argue, he's walking away from me.

"Jayden. Keep an eye on her, and guard the door at all times," he speaks to the man at the door. To Jayden. He seems like any other guard, but by the way Dante rests his hand on his shoulder, I sense there's more to this - maybe a friendship.

The door closes and I fall into the chair, exhausted.

I can't do anything, I can't fight anymore. I just have to do what he says.

I look at the man standing at the door, his hands intertwined, folded, as he keeps his eyes on me.

Jayden.

Fear paralyzes me as I realize Dante has left me alone in the room with him.

Why is he here? What is he going to do to me?

As if he reads my mind, his gaze suddenly softens, “Don’t worry. I’m not here to hurt you. Just to keep you safe, and make sure you don’t run.”

I look at him a little longer – he's very different looking from Dante. He has blonde hair, a chiselled face, and a scar across his cheek that makes me wonder what he’s been through.

“How’d you get that,” I point at my cheek, gesturing towards his scar.

He smiles softly, shaking his head, “An attack. On Dante. One of our men’s turned out to be a mole, and took a knife out on him. I came in front before he could attack Dante, and in the middle of our tussle, he managed to cut my face, deep.”

“Oh, wow.” I lower my eyes, feeling a sense of empathy for him. “You’re really loyal to him, aren’t you? Why? He's a bad man.”

He scoffs, “All of us our bad men, some more than others. But, not Dante. He may have done things that are...immoral. But, he’s not some cold-hearted killer. All of us just got dragged into this life, and once you’re in, you can’t leave. Especially if you’re the kingpin.”

He pauses, the silence heavy with intense emotions, as if he’s thinking about something, perhaps his past.

He gives me a small smile before speaking again, “Dante saved me from the streets when I was just a kid. My parents, they were into drugs.

They abandoned me, and I had to fend for myself. That's when Dante found me – a little kid, struggling to find food for the day. He took me in, taught me the ins and outs of this life and made me who I am. I owe it all to him, my life, everything."

"I'm sorry you had to go through that, and get stuck in this world," I bring up my head, an empathetic gaze meeting his eyes.

He lets out a small laugh, "Don't be sorry. This is the card life dealt me, and after the things I saw growing up as kid, this is pretty good."

I smile at him, at the kindness he holds in his heart despite the world he's in.

At the same time, something stirs in my heart, a kind of warmth for Dante. I've only seen a dangerous side to him – *the side that kidnaps me.*

But, there's clearly more. He's got a kindness in him, and the more I hear Jayden talk, the more I want to get to know to him – to see that side. The side that's full of love.

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Slowly, I get off the chair and make my way to the bed, laying on it as sleeps pulls on my eyes.

This is not what I expected my life to turn into. I came here to find myself, to find peace. But instead, I've found myself in the middle of mafia politics, and I have no power.

As the thoughts consume my mind, I find myself drifting into a deep sleep.

But, my worries are only replaced by something much worse.

I'm back there, in that car - locked, trapped, unable to do anything, help anyone.

"Scarlett, baby, hold on, okay? Mommy's going to come get you. Just stay where you are."

My eyes come to my father, unconscious, his face tainted red from the blood covering his face.

I can see where he's hurt - his head.

"Mommy, is daddy going to be okay?"

"Yeah baby, just hold on, okay? Someone will…someone will help, soon," her voice begins to fade out.

"Mommy! Mommy, can you hear me?"

"Yes, baby. Mommy just has to sh-shut her eyes," she speaks in a low whisper until her eyes close and she's not speaking anymore.

"Mom! Mom! Mommy, wake up!

Wake up!

Scarlett!

Wake up!

My eyes break open with force, my lungs gasping for air. I see Dante standing above me, my body thrashing against his.

"Scarlett! It's just me. It's Dante," he wraps his arms around my body, tightening his hold as I beat against his chest, tears rolling down my face.

"No, let me go!"

"Shh, you're safe," he runs his hand over my head.

I give in - give in to his embrace, his touch, the comfort.

I let myself cry, let myself process that memory. That is, until I realize who's holding me.

I pull back, reaching for the gun on the side table and aim it at him.

"Get out."

Chapter 4: Fake Relationship

Dante's POV

As the storm blows through everything tonight, I stand in the kitchen, cooking pasta for dinner. The rain is pouring and the thunder is at its peak.

I try focusing on the dinner but I can't stop looking at Scarlett who watches me like a hawk, sitting on the table with her arms crossed. I would say I'm quite unpleasant to be around most times, but right now the roles have reversed.

I feel a palpable tension between us, but there's something else–a softness, an understanding. As much as we come from very different worlds, she carries deep pain with her. And deep down, some sadistic part of me feels good to be around it.

But, maybe that's because she's the first person I've met who seems to carry the kind of pain I feel. In the depths of the darkness, as the horrors creep up on my mind, I go back to that day, the day my father was taken from me.

And the way she reacted that night, the way she sobbed in my arms after the nightmare, I can tell she's been through something that's just as bad, if not worse.

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"I think I should make it clear. I don't like it when someone cooks my food. I can do it on my own." She mutters, her words the equivalent of spitting poison at me.

"That's too bad. No one else cooks in my kitchen," I reply to her, avoiding eye contact as I focus on stirring the sauce. "Besides, you need to eat. Making you starve isn't the reason I've kept you here. I need you alive."

"I admire your idea of protecting me. Kidnap me and then feed me. Yeah, that will make me like you," she scoffs.

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"What is wrong with you?" I sigh, looking up at her, "I never wanted this for you. But you're involved now. You can't be out there alone, it's not safe. And frankly, it's your fault. Maybe if you kept to yourself instead of eavesdropping on my conversations, neither of us would have to endure this."

She goes silent in an instant, and I am forced to turn my head towards her to see if she's still there. Her eyes are softer, no longer filled with a deep hatred. She begins biting her lip, nervously, as if she doesn't know what to say anymore.

"Why can't you tell me everything? I mean I'm a part of this now. I never wanted to be, but…"

"Once I tell you everything, you can never leave. You'll be stuck here forever," I shake my head, walking towards her and putting a bowl of pasta in front of her.

She looks down at the bowl. "I hope there's no poison."

I roll my eyes, "I have more creative ways of killing people."

She gives me a deadpan look, the fork stopping right before her mouth which hangs agape.

"I'm kidding, Scarlett."

She blinks, looking down at her food and taking a bite.

Her shoulders seem to relax as she eats and she mumbles, "I hate this."

"I know." I take a bite. Our feelings mirror the storm outside, chaotic and uncontrollable, swirling with intensity.

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My mind goes back to the night she had the nightmare, and I can't help but wonder what her life was like before she came here. Who is she, and what made her the way she is?

As I watch her eat, I can't hold myself back any longer, blurting out the question, "What was that nightmare about? The one you had two nights ago?"

She stops eating, the fork held right in front of her mouth as she's about to take a bite. "That's none of your business."

"I'm protecting you. So, if there's something bothering you, I think it is my business," I grit back at her, leaning back in my chair.

"Well, it's not something i want to talk about. Now or ever."

I stare at her a little longer, trying to read what's going on in that mind of hers.

But, suddenly the light flickers, and boom, it's dark. The storm intensifies, the thunder rumbling louder, and it scares the living crap out of her. I stand up, watching her panic.

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"Dante?" she mumbles. "What's going on?" Her voice trembles.

"Looks like the power is out." I respond, keeping calm because if I act tense, things are going to escalate. I grab a flashlight from the counter. "I'm going to check the fuse-box. Stay inside."

Scarlett walks behind me, grabbing the edge of the door, "You can't leave me in here alone. I'm coming."

"No. Stay inside. It's bad out there. I'll be back."

"No. I want to come, please," her words are hurried as her brows furrow, her eyes full of fear.

I walk back inside, putting my hand on her shoulder assuring her that I'll be back in a minute. "Don't worry. I promise, I'm coming back. You're safe here."

Our eyes meet and somehow, that's enough to assure her. "Okay," she nods.

"Just lock the door, okay? I'll be back in less than a minute. Jayden, come with me." I repeat myself. I don't want to leave Scarlett alone, but I have to take Jayden with me in case the whole power grid is out, and the problem goes beyond the fuse box.

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I see hesitation in her eyes, but she agrees. I turn back and walk out the door, closing it behind me. The storm is at its peak and I can't let her fear take control. I need to fix this.

With my flashlight, I cut through the pouring rain and make it to the fuse box. But something doesn't feel right.

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Goddamn it, I shouldn't have left her alone.

I look around and see that the other houses still have their lights on, all except for mine. It feels like a part of a game, and my paranoia instantly kicks in. Even if they don't know she's here, they know I'm here.

As soon as we reach the fuse box, I suddenly hear a loud crash.

Scarlett.

My heart skips a beat.

"Jayden, screw the generator. Go inside, now. I'll deal with this." I yell at him, my voice muffled by the sound of rain and thunder.

He nods, "Be careful," before running off.

I open the fuse box and find one of the wires disconnected. Instantly, I fix it before running inside.

But, I'm shocked when I see what's happening. Scarlett's fighting off a man–kicking and throwing punches in every direction. Jayden's on the other side of the room, tackling another. She's outnumbered, but that clearly hasn't been an issue. I see two men lying on the floor, groaning in pain. One guy lunges at her, but she fights him off, drop kicking him in the face, and he falls to the floor.

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Where did she learn how to fight like this?

Suddenly, a man in a black mask comes up behind her and pulls her down, choking her neck from the back.

"Let her go. She's not a part of this." I roar.

Before I make it to her, Jayden runs up behind him, hitting him in the head with the butt of his gun. The man falls to the ground, letting Scarlett go, dropping her to the floor as she gasps for air.

Her head hits the ground, and her hand comes to it, her throat releasing a loud groan.

I run to her, picking her up and putting her on the couch.

"Scarlett, keep your eyes open," I lightly smack her face, bringing her back to consciousness.

“Dante.”

“Yes, it’s me. You’re okay. Just keep your eyes open.”

By the time I walk back to Jayden, more of my men have swarmed the room.

Jayden holds onto the attackers, tying them with a rope and calling more of my men to take them away.

“It’s them,” he whispers in my ear.

“Are you positive?” I question him.

“Yes.” He walks out of the house with a gun searching for any others that may be hiding.

I rush back to Scarlett who’s color is slowly returning back to her face. I sit down, holding her hand.

“You okay?” I search her face and body for any wounds or injuries.

“I thought I was gonna die,” she lets out a small laugh, giving me a small smile.

“Not when I’m here,” I run my hand over her head, looking at her face, feeling the pain she feels.

I notice her arm bleeding, a gash on it inflicted from a piece of broken glass. I grab a cloth and run it under cold water before turning to Scarlett. She’s still finding it hard to breathe properly, but she sits up, using all her strength.

“Come here. Give me your hand.”

“It’s fine,” she shakes her head. “I just need water.”

“It’s not fine,” I feel the rage coursing through my veins. Whoever did this, they’re going to wish they were never born. “Hold this around your arm, I’ll get you some water.”

When I come back, she’s holding her head in her hands.

“Are you okay? Do you feel sick? Is your head okay,” I grab her face, searching for any sign of an internal bleed.

“I’m okay, just tired.”

“You did well, Scarlett. Who knew you could tackle four men twice your size,” I press the cloth down on her wound.

"Me. I was a Martial Art student for like, five years," she smiles at me. "Are you proud?"

"So proud. In fact, it's making me wonder if you wanted me to kidnap you this entire time. I mean, God knows you could've fought me off that day," a small grin spreads over my mouth.

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"Uh, yeah, you need access to your arms for that, asshole," she lets out a laugh, and the sound is melodic. It spreads a warmth in my chest, one I'm not fortunate enough to feel often in this cold world I live in.

But with her around, I feel that warmth growing with each passing second.

"Well, you surprised me," I smirk, gently touching her arm where her blood lingers, cleaning it up, "Does this hurt?"

"No, it's fine. Just stings a little," she looks up at me, our eyes meeting.

I say nothing. All of this is too much. The feeling of her skin under my fingers, the pain in her eyes, the shock stiffening her body.

I hate whoever did this to her, and I vow to make them pay.

"See I can protect myself."

"Of course, you can, bella." Laughing, we lock eyes with each other. "But we have a problem."

"What now?" she rolls her eyes.

"Now that they think you're involved, the closer you are to me the safer, you'll be. And after this attack, I have to show my enemies that you are not to be messed with, that you are under my protection. I need to make a public statement."

She stiffens, her eyes narrowing at me, "You've literally kidanpped me. What else are we supposed to do now? Get married?"

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"Perhaps we ease into it," I take a deep breath before continuing, "let's start with you being my girlfriend."

Deleted[Guest User]: We fake it,

Deleted[Guest User]: We pretend to be a couple

"What? You're kidding, right? Now I have to play this game? Pretending to be your girlfriend?" She says in a sullen tone.

"For your safety. This way you can be around me, and people will think twice before coming after you," I assure her.

She pauses, thinking. After a few minutes, she responds, shaking her head, "God… Fine."

I help her get up from the floor and lean against the wall, watching her put a bandage on her cut. “You’ll need to be ready for tomorrow night.”

“What? Why? What’s tomorrow night?” She looks at me with frustration.

“There’s a mafia event and the stakes are high. I need you to come with me as my girlfriend. We’ll make our debut there,” I respond, taking a deep breath.

“That’ll make me a prominent target though,” she raises a brow.

“The opposite. That’s when you know people will hesitate coming close to you. They won’t touch Dante Levicii’s girlfriend.”

“You sound confident.”

“No, I am confident. As long as you’re mine, nothing can happen to you,” I take a step closer to her, my voice a low whisper.

“As long as I’m yours.”

Chapter 5: Into the Lion's Den

Scarlett's POV

I don't think I can pull this off.

I stand in front of the closet where my dress is hanging. Dante bought this for me in the morning - his first gift to me as my 'boyfriend'.

God, am I doing the right thing?

I shake away the doubts and get dressed. I don't have a choice, and tonight, I need to impress everyone. These people are ruthless, and I can't look weak. I need to fit into their world.

The dress Dante chose for me is every girl's dream - elegant, black satin draping over my body with a laced blouse. I don't feel like myself. In fact, I feel like I'm in a completely different world altogether.

That's because you are, Scarlett.

I run my fingers down the dress, anxious about what the night holds for me. No matter how happy I am, I can't shake off the nervous feeling right now. I don't know what the mafia world is all about, and I'm just a

writer. I've never lived this life of danger. It's new, and full of dread and pain.

And it scares me to say this, but it exhilarates me, even if just a little bit. I hear voices in my mind. *Threat. Mafia. Danger.*

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I swallow the lump in my throat, adjusting the straps of my dress and staring at myself in the mirror, questioning my existence. It's like I'm wearing a mask right now - pretending to be someone I'm not and can never be.

How did I end up here?

It hits me that I'm left with no choice. Not after what happened last night. I agree with what Dante says, the closer I am to him, the safer I am. He's the only one who can keep me alive now.

Breathe, it's not hard.

I bend down and pick my silver heels from under the bed, putting them on. One final look, and I'm done. The woman I see reflecting back is calm and composed, when in reality I'm a mess.

Mafia world? Seriously. You took your fantasy books too seriously, Scarlett.

I glance at the door waiting for Dante who's about to arrive any minute. I've been through a lot in my life, but this is something new. It feels like I'm about to walk on fire, like all this night is going to be is survival.

The door opens and Dante stands in it's way. He looks at me in awe, standing there frozen as his eyes roam my body.

"Shall we?" I ask him.

"Yes." He reaches out for my hand as we walk out of the house.

After driving a few miles into the city, we reach a club. I step out of the car and instantly feel the bass pounding as we walk towards the door. The bright lights flash in my eyes, and I see a sea of bodies dancing in rhythm. This isn't some random party - it's the party of the rich.

It's extravagant, and I've never experienced anything like it before. Dante walks beside me, his hands on my waist. He holds me close, possessively, gently guiding me through the chaos.

We move towards the VIP section, past those velvet ropes and sharp-eyed bouncers staring at us. I don't see a single familiar face, while Dante clearly knows everyone by the way they clear the path for him. They know who Dante is, and now I'm supposed to be his.

A man in a black tuxedo appears out of nowhere, “Dante… What’s up, my man?” and clings to him. They seem close.

Dante introduces me to him, “This is Scarlett…” and before he finishes, the man interrupts him, “Don’t tell me you have a girlfriend! My man finally settled, huh?”

Dante shakes his head, laughing - a sound so foreign to me, it shocks me for a moment.

“Yes…” he looks at me.

“I’m so happy for you two. Enjoy your evening.” He pats Dante’s shoulder and walks away, welcoming other guests.

“Who was that?” I scream into Dante’s ear over the thumping music.

“That man is Oliver. One of my oldest friends and a banker we do all our business dealing through. This is his party, actually,” Dante looks around, scanning the room.

The nights goes on, and everyone dances, getting drunk and doing other highly immoral things. Everyone except Dante. It’s all fun and lively, that is until Dante whispers, “Fuck,” under his breath.

"What's wrong?" I turn to face him.

I know things are not right when Dante's expressions stiffen and his grip around my waist tightens. He grabs my hand and we walk to the host, Oliver. "What is Viktor doing here?" Dante grits out, his jaw clenching.

"Listen, Viktor and I have a new alliance. You just keep your distance, okay? He won't do anything."

A tall, sharp man approaches us, smiling, "Dante." He shakes hands with him. I see the hesitation in Dante's body language. "You must be Scarlett." He winks at me.

Who is this guy?

"I must say, Dante, she's quite a find." Leaning close to his ear.

"I'm sorry to interrupt, butI can hear you. And I'm a handful, actually. Not that great," I give him a sarcastic smile.

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I meet his gaze, forcing him to smile, "I'm more than just a mere find." A gentle tilt of my head is enough to make him intimidated.

"I bet you are." He chuckles, putting his hand forward to shake mine.

Dante stands there silent. I know rage is boiling over him. Just as Viktor tries to come closer, Dante shields me. He holds me tighter and looks right into his eyes.

"Sharing was never your thing. Bad luck." He stares into Dante's eyes and scans me.

Viktor makes me feel uneasy but at the same time, I notice something else- Dante's jealousy. It's not evident but it exists.

Without a word, Dante pulls me to the dance floor with his hands firmly around my waist. I try to pull away, but it feels nice. My heart skips a beat when he makes me twirl into him. I look right into his eyes and I know there's a sense of longing in him, a longing to feel the kind of love that gives you a purpose to keep going.

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"What are you doing?" I question him, but he silences me with a look.

"Keep dancing and pretend we're enjoying." He whispers, leaning into my ear. I let out a laugh - a fake laugh. We dance to the rhythm of the music and feel our bodies flowing as one. I don't fight it.

He looks into my eyes and whispers, "The danger, Scarlett… It's around. Stay close." The music is so loud that I can't figure out what he's saying other than 'Danger.' I bite my lips, fighting the urge to argue. The

tension in his voice makes me nervous. I know he's concerned for me that he holds me close when someone approaches.

"But you kidnapped me…" I tell him.

"It was for an important reason. I had no option. Take you or watch them take you." He shakes his head, nervously scanning the crowd.

I can't stop looking at him. I now understand that he's not a bad person. At least not with me. He wanted to keep me safe, he genuinely cared.

"You could've told me," I tell him, looking at his face.

"And let you run away…" In a swift motion, he pulls me close, "I can't lose you now, bella."

"Why do you call me bella? What does it mean?" I stare into his eyes, panting, my heart beating out of my chest.

He stares at me for a beat, his fingers caressing my waist, moving up and down my back, "Beautiful. It means you're beautiful."

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I feel my breath get stuck in my throat as the passion in his eyes burns brighter.

He's been calling me beautiful all this time, and I didn't even know it?

He finds me…beautiful?

Suddenly, a car comes out of nowhere, speeding at us the wrong way. Dante swerves, the shock of it jolting my body towards the dashboard, my head hitting it. Dante presses down on the brake, and instantly looks to me, his hands coming to my face.

"Are you okay," he heaves out, searching me for any wounds, or signs of pain.

I feel a sharp pain in my head, and bring my hand to my forehead, brushing over it.

Memories start flooding my mind, memories of that night, the night my parents died. I feel myself breathing harder, trying to fill my lungs with oxygen, tears stinging my eyes.

"Hey, you're okay, bella. Breathe," Dante's eyes find mine. "Just follow my voice, and take three deep breaths with me."

He starts inhaling and exhaling, and I follow him, closing my eyes and bringing myself back to the present. Once I calm down, Dante looks into my eyes, giving me a kiss on the forehead. "It's okay, you're okay. But,

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we need to get out of here, now. It's not safe. We're practically sitting ducks."

Then, he turns back to face the steering wheel, and drives us home.

We return home from the party and the air between us feels heavy with a thousand unspoken words. Dante opens the door and makes way for me to step inside. Suddenly, it feels comfortable here, like I'm home, like I don't want to leave. Tonight, I witnessed something I never thought I would–Dante's soft side.

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I sit on the couch, take my shoes off, and rest my head against the back. My head still buzzes with all the loud music, my ears ringing. Dante sits next to me, takes his tie off, and looks at me. It's not a threatening look, it's a sincere one, and I find myself wanting to never look away.

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"You were quiet on the way back," Dante looks straight into my eyes. "What's going on? Do you feel okay? Are you hurt?"

I sigh, unsure of what to say, but I feel it's time I let my guard down. I face him, my feet on the couch and I tell him, tell him the one thing I haven't been able to run away from yet.

"My parents," I take a deep breath, turning to face him. "I was eight when my parents died… in a car crash… and I don't know how but I was the only one who survived in the car."

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"What happened?"

"I don't remember much except for the moment I realized this was it. We were driving back from a dinner. It was late at night, and out of nowhere, this car hit us from the front as we were passing the intersection. Our car totaled. I was stuck in my car seat, and because my parents were in the front, they felt most of the impact. They didn't make it through the night," I feel the tears streaming down my face.

"That must be tough for you." He lifts his head up, a concerned look on his face.

"I never let anyone come close to me after that. I always felt that I'd end up losing them as well. So, I buried myself in work in the city. When that became too much, I moved here to bury myself in my writing. But, well, God had other plans," I give him a soft smile, tears streaming down my face.

He nods, holding my hand, "I know how you feel, actually. I lost my father when I was nine."

I stare at him, shocked, and my tears freeze. "He had made some enemies in the mafia world when he proposed making changes, changes that they thought were 'too soft' and would cut their profits. When they saw the influence he was gathering, someone from one of the gangs sent his men to kill him. The worst part is I couldn't do anything other than hide in the closet. After that, I took control of everything, hoping to find who killed him that night. I haven't given up ever since."

I stop blinking, "So did you?"

"No, I haven't," he shakes his head. "I'm still looking. But, Scarlett, I've seen what this world is like, what it does to good people. That's why I felt I had to protect you. I simply can't afford to lose you as well now."

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My heart warms at the sound of that.

He really does care about me, and I realize, I think I can trust him. Not just with my life, but with my heart, too.

"What about your mother? Where is she?"

He scoffs, letting out a small laugh, "Well, she died during childbirth. Ironic, isn't it. I've been carrying this death and destruction with me ever since I came into the world."

My heart breaks for him, for the hard life he's had to lead. "Don't say that. None of it was your fault," I bring my hand to his face, and he leans into it.

For the first time, I understand his nature. We both carry the weight of our past, the burden of having no one, the grief of losing everyone. "We both survived. That's all that matters." I smile, gripping his hand tighter.

He looks at me, his eyes flickering, "Yes… we did."

We lock eyes with each other and he leans in to kiss me but I stop him. "I think we should head to bed."

"Yeah, sure…" he pulls back and I get up to go back to my room.

I climb into bed and lay down thinking about what Dante and I just talked about. I pull up the covers, close my eyes, and try to sleep.

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It'll be okay.

Suddenly, I hear my door open, and look towards it to find Dante walking in. He's shirtless, wearing only a pair of grey sweatpants. His eyes meet mine, and in that moment, I know what's about to happen.He walks to me, his hands gently sliding over my clothes. He leans down, getting on top of me as he gently trails his tongue on my neck, kissing it passionately.

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As sleep takes over, I begin dreaming.

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I moan. "*Dante.*"

And keep moaning his name again and again. He looks at me and pulls me closer to him. His touch sends sparks rushing through my body. Every kiss makes me want more.

His hand cups my cheek, his thumb caressing my lip, "I can't stay away from you, bella. You, you drive me insane," he lowers his head and whispers against my ear.

Without thinking straight, I pull him to face me, crashing my lips onto his.

This feeling, kissing him, it's the peace I've been looking for.

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My eyes blink open, only to find him standing there, over me. Staring at me. I sit up as he looks right into his eyes, standing above me, h

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Chapter 6: Rising Tensions

Dante's POV

Today's brunch day is on the lakeside. I watch Scarlett as we both walk hand-in-hand towards the guests. She finally gets to meet the people who I trust, my family.

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She smiles at me, "It's a beautiful day. But, I am a little nervous. What if they don't like me?"

"Not possible," I smile at her, holding her hand even tighter by my side.

The moment she looks into my eyes, I forget everything around us. She makes me feel joy, pure, untainted joy.

"Hello everyone," I say out loud and they all smile and welcome us.

I introduce her to everyone and as we sit down, I see Scarlett interacting with them. I see James's wife, the arrogant one, laughing at something Scarlett just said. It's like she's been here forever, like she fits right in.

At one moment we are sitting there peacefully and at the next, we're not.

The echo of a gunshot shatters the calm atmosphere and my instincts kick in.

"Get down," I yell.

Amidst the chaos, I run towards Scarlett.

She seems panicked and I grab her arm pulling her under the table.

"Are you okay?" I ask her.

"Yes…what's going on?" She yells.

"Stay close," I growl, my heart racing. As I help others evacuate safely, I spot the attackers. I know they are here because of me. They want to kill me, to take me down.

Without hesitation, I shield Scarlett and we sprint towards the car. She's right behind me, ducked when suddenly she picks up the gun and starts firing back, her aim precise. "Let's go." I yank her into the car and we drive off. The tires begin screeching as we accelerate. Right now my heart is pounding and it's only because of the fear of losing her.

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Deleted[Guest User]: She manages to drop two men confidently. I'm left stunned but I can't waste time here.

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We manage to reach my safe house and as soon as we go inside, I lose it on her.

“What did you do?” I yell, storming across the room. “You could’ve died.”

“I tried helping.” She argues back, folding her arms at me.

“I know you did” I walk towards her, grabbing her arms. “But Scarlett, you need to understand something. This is my life and these are my duties and I can’t abandon them. As long as you’re with me, and in my world, you’re going to be around danger. So, I can’t have you stopping to help every time something happens. I can’t afford to lose you,” my words are full of desperation, full of love.

I love this girl.

“I know Dante.” She responds.

“You’ve become something I can’t let go of,” my voice breaks and I hug her tightly, pressing her head into my chest as she wraps her arms around my waist.

“Scarlett, I can’t pretend anymore,” I whisper against her ear. She looks at me questioningly, her eyes conflicting.

“I don’t know how, but I can’t either.” She mumbles back, her voice soft and eyes teary. “But, I’m also scared. This is dangerous, Dante.”

“I know it’s dangerous. But, I don’t have it in me to pretend like you don’t drive me insane. The way you sound, the way you smell, the way you look - every passing moment of every day you haunt me, Scarlett. And there isn’t enough danger in the world to make me walk away from that.” I grab her hand, gently.

The tension between us finally snaps and I reach for her waist to pull her close. I drop my head lower, brushing my lips over hers, feeling the warmth of her breath. As our lips collide, I feel her heart beating against mine. This one kiss is enough to make my chest feel lighter, unburdened, as if it’s going to solve all my problems.

In fact, I think it just did.

Her hands move up my chest as we kiss harder. I begin undressing her as we tangle in the heat of the moment. I roughly pull her dress off, revealing her bra and stockings. “I want to make you mine tonight, bella.”

“I want to be yours,” she moans in my ear as she pulls my neck closer.

I unhook her bra and being my hands to her boobs, squeezing them with my fingers, licking her neck.

I feel myself getting hard and pick her up, making her straddle me as I kiss and suck her nipples. I move to my room, sitting onto the bed as her legs tighten around me. Then, she starts rocking her body back and forth, her pussy rubbing right over my erection.

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She takes the lead and pushes me on my back. I lay down flat and she unzips my pants, taking them off. She comes back up and kisses my lips, before moving down, using her tongue to lick down my chest to my dick. She wraps her mouth around my cock, sucking me, taking it so far back I can feel the tip hit her throat.

She holds it there, her eyes getting teary, before pulling it out and looking up at me as she pumps it.

“You’re such a good girl, mia bella,” I bring my hand to her face, moving it back as I weave my fingers into her hair, fisting it.

“Come up,” I pull her. “On your back, darling.”

I lay her down, running my hands over her body, it’s curves, feeling every inch of it. Moving back, I lower my head and and spit on her pussy, rubbing two fingers over her clit.

“God, you’re so wet for me,” I look at her as I penetrate two fingers inside.

She lets out a moan as my fingers quicken their pace, and I can feel her pussy pulsating around my fingers as she comes all over them.

“Dante, I want you–I want you inside me,” she pants, pulling me down to her face, kissing me.

She moans hard as I move my cock into her tight pussy, filling her up completely. My kiss swallows her moans as I thrust harder in her, and watch as her body writhes with pleasure.

“Rub yourself,” I groan, pulling her hair back.

I put her hands on her clit and make her rub herself, pounding into her until her legs are trembling and she’s coming on my cock. I can’t hold myself any longer, the feeling or her pussy around my cock bringing me to release. I pull out, pumping my cock as I come on her stomach, before dropping onto her, kissing her.

Now, there’s no more pretending. Now, we’re giving in.

I hold her close as she snuggles into me, gently running her finger through my hair. I haven’t felt loved like this in a while, and I forgot how good it feels to just be. I forgot living can be free of pain.

Her fierce eyes make me feel as if she's made to be with me. She gives me strength, strength to open myself up to her, to experience more than just hatred and danger.

Just as things seem to ease down, and we close our eyes, there's a banging on my door. Scarlett fixes the sheets over her body, before I respond.

"Come in."

One of my men opens the door slightly, his voice frantic, "Sir, it's Jayden. He's been taken."

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"What? Who did this?!"

"Viktor Russo."

"Fuck," I lower my head.

"Sir," his voice breaks out meekly. "They want Scarlett…"

Chapter 7: Dangerous Attractions

Scarlett's POV

"That can't happen," yells Dante.

Jayden is one of his closest men, more like a good friend and I know how much he means to Dante. Years ago, he saved his life when Dante's enemies almost had him. Since then, the two have been inseparable apparently. He's not just another guard of his, Dante thinks of him as a brother.

Dante and his men are now planning an attack, a plan to get Jayden back. I know he's going to fight me about it, but I want to help. I have to help.

He turns back, picking the glass and smashing it on the floor. "I'm not risking your life here. All this time, I kept you here to save you, only to put you at more risk. Not happening," Dante argues. He walks back and forth trying to think straight.

I don't know if this is the right thing to do, but I stand in front of him, arms crossed. "Look at me. I need to do something to help him. He doesn't deserve this, not after everything he's done for you and me. He's saved both us when we needed it. Remember? We owe him."

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"I know, and there are several other ways to do that. This is too dangerous." He hesitates.

"I can't sit here and watch you walk out there by yourself, and maybe get yourself killed," I argue back.

"Scarlett, honey, this isn't up for any debate. You're not going and that's final." He replies, frustrated.

"I'm not afraid…Do you not remember how I saved myself from those men?"

"Yes, until you ended up in a chokehold and Jayden had to save your ass," he scoffs.

"Well, it's a good thing Jayden's going to be there," I reply smugly.

He rolls his eyes at me, and I can tell he doesn't have an answer to that.

"You and I, we can do this. I don't fear anything now that I have you by my side," I take his hand into mine.

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Deleted[Guest User]: He stands there frozen.

"No. It's decided. You're not going, Scarlett. I can't risk your life like that." He lets go of my hand and sits back on the couch.

"Listen, nothing is going to happen. I can be bait for them, which can give you time to prepare for the fight. You know I can do this. Just please, trust me."

I can tell I'm getting through to him, "Please let me help you," I gently place my hands on his shoulder.

For a brief moment, he feels torn. From wanting to protect me to dealing with the brutal situation and getting Jayden back.

He exhales, shaking his head, "Fine."

It's the next morning, and Dante stands ahead of me, concentrating on what to do. "You go first. As far as I know Viktor, he's aware you're with me. What he doesn't know is the ambush we've prepared."

I feel nervous, "What do I do when I get inside? I'd have no way to contact you."

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"You wear this," Dante says, putting his hand forward and giving me a small earpiece. "I'll be listening to everything he says. Just keep talking to him, don't try pulling any move inside. When I give the signal, then we ambush."

"I need a safe word?" I ask him.

"Looks like all those books you read are paying off. Good thinking."

"Safehouse." I tell him.

He shakes his head, letting out a small laugh," Sure, I guess."

We don't have much time, Viktor has Jayden and I need to get inside before things go wrong.

I force myself to smile, "Don't worry, I got it."

When Dante's men told Viktor's people they can have me in exchange for Jayden, they sent us an address where I'm supposed to go alone and meet Viktor in order for the exchange to happen.

I drive myself to the location, and reach an abandoned building, one that looks like an old warehouse. I step out of the car and it's like everyone knows who I am. Without hesitation, the guards let me in and my blood runs cold the minute I see him.

Viktor.

He's standing in the middle of an empty room, his men on every corner. The walls are made of concrete, and there's cracks all over, water dripping

from them, and mold spreading around.

He smirks, “Look who it is.” I can smell the hatred emanating from him. His eyes gleam as he walks closer to me, “You’re daring. I wasn’t expecting Dante to send his pretty girlfriend alone, or at all. I mean, I knew Jayden was important to him, life debt and all, but to choose him over you? I guess you’re still too new, just another toy amongst the many.” He lets out a laugh, shaking his head, “It’s fine. He'd tire of you soon enough anyway.”

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As if he knows what I’m up to.

“Let Jayden go. You have me.”

“What’s the rush? Now, I have both of you. And bringing Dante down has been my plan all along. You see, this is my world, and these people, I own them,” he laughs maniacally, his back now facing me.

I step back, and he turns in an instant, “One wrong move and you’ll regret coming here.”

I stay firm on my stance, “Let Jayden go. We did as you promised.”

My anxiety rises but I keep calm thinking about Dante. He has high expectations from me and I can’t let him down.

I can do this. I have to. There’s no turning back.

Suddenly, all the doors close and Viktor circles me. “You thought you could come in here and save the day? Let me burst your bubble, honey. You’re dying here with Jayden.” He mocks me.

“You wanted me. I’m here. Let him go.” I yell.

The confrontation gets heated when I realize we’ve been played. It was never about me or Jayden. Viktor wants to destroy Dante.

“Let him go and we can deal with this peacefully. Nobody needs to get harmed.” I speak, firmly.

“Listen. You don’t tell me what to do. I’ve been waiting for this moment–waiting for the opportunity to destroy Dante.” He takes a step closer.

“Let Jayden go.” I stand face-to-face with him.

I can tell Viktor is losing his calm when he walks towards me and pushes me on the ground. “You die here, tonight.” He picks up his gun and points it at me.

In the chaos, I yell, “Safehouse.”

This leaves him puzzled as he has no idea what I'm talking about. He continued pointing the gun at me while I lay there on the floor.

"It's over, Scarlett. You lost. No matter what you say now, it can't save you."

"Maybe. Maybe not. I'm smarter than you think." I let out a knowing laugh.

Suddenly the door bursts open and Dante shoots his hand, making him lose control of the gun.

Now.

Without hesitation I get up and push him to the floor, getting my hands on his gun.

"Told you." I laugh.

I see Dante running towards me and shielding me from everything. It's messed up. I see Dante's men controlling Viktor's safe house and he lies there begging for his life.

"You think you can threaten my girlfriend and walk away? Count till three Viktor." Dante dominates.

He kicks Dante's hand and jumps up. Both men fight arm to arm, with full strength until Dante takes control of him. "I told you that going against me isn't going to help."

He laughs hysterically, "There's something I want you to know."
"Speak." Dante puts his foot on his chest before he pulls the trigger.

"Don't you want to know who killed your father?" he asks.

Dante, in a state of shock, lowers his gun, "Who?"

I stay firm, feeling that it's a trick to gain energy to fight Dante back.

"Dante, don't."

"Speak, you son of a bitch," his voice resounds through the room.

"I did…" he confesses, a grin on his lips.

And those are his last words.

Because Dante shoots him, point blank.

Chapter 8: Escalating Feelings

Dante's POV

We drive home hand-in-hand, knowing we made it. Scarlett walks inside our home first as I speak to my men, telling. As soon as I walk through the door, she jumps on me, kissing my lips roughly and taking my clothes off on the way to the bedroom. "I need you now, Dante."

"Come on, let's release our stress tonight." I laugh holding her in my arms, entering the bedroom as I throw her on the bed.

"Fuck me." She moans.

"Easy tiger. Let me me have my fun."

I begin licking her neck, kissing her down to her navel, ripping off the buttons of her shirt. My hands comes to her head, and I fist her hair, pulling it harder.

I pull off her pants, her panty soaking wet. I move it to the side and lick her clit. The sounds of her pants, those desperate moans, turn me on, and I find myself losing all inhibitions. I turn her onto her stomach and begin fingering her as I eat her out.

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"Fuck Dante, harder." She moans louder, holding the sheets.

I take my jeans off and pump my cock, before rubbing it over her clit. She's wet enough and I put her in doggy style, gently pushing my cock inside her tight pussy.

"Aah…" she moans, trying to move away. I hold her back from her waist and begin fucking her rough.

I feel her dripping as my dick moves in and out of her, making her pant and grip the sheets. I pull out, lifting her and throwing her onto her back.

She lays back, looking at me with eyes full of desire, and I fuck her in missionary, bending down to suck her hard nipples.

"I'm going to come," she moans out. And it's my cue to fuck her harder. I pound her harder, rubbing her clit until she reaches her climax. Her legs shake because of the orgasm, but I continue fucking her, not stopping. Her moans echo in the bedroom as I thrust into her. A few hard strokes later, I feel myself coming and pull out, ejaculating on her stomach.

I fall down onto the bed beside her, trying to catch my breath as she wipes off my cum from her stomach and jumps in to cuddle with me. I hold her close like always, kissing her forehead.

"I don't know how else to say this, but I'm falling in love with you, bella."

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She smiles, looking at me, "I think I'm falling in love with you, too," she kisses me.

"Let's make this work. Because I can't imagine a life without you."

She looks at me with bright eyes, as if she wanted me to say this to her all along.

"I promise to always protect you from this mafia mess. I'm sorry I dragged you into this, but I will never ever let anyone hurt you," I press my lips to her forehead.

"Listen, I'm with you in everything. Every mafia king needs a queen. And I can be a good one." She laughs.

"Oh, I think you've proven that." I nod.

"But hey, can we stay away from this for just a while? I need us to spend time together. And be an actual couple. I want to have sex in every room, sleep with you, and go out on dates without any threats. I want to do so much," she traces my face with her fingers.

“We’ll do everything you want. Don’t worry.” I kiss her hands.

“And, I want children…” she laughs, softly.

I laugh too, looking down at her, knowing that a child with her would be the best thing to happen to me.

“You’re rushing. Not now, but someday soon don’t worry.” I assure her.

A few days pass by, and Scarlett and I live happily together. I don’t know what’s happening to me, I smile more now, feel less pain, less lonely. I love being with her, being around her.

She’s changed my life for the best, and I don’t regret anything.

Scarlett and I moved out of our old neighborhood and into my mansion where we spend most of our time now. I was once a don who people feared, but now, I’m making allies, leaving all the bad blood behind. I’ve learned many things with her, the first being forgiveness and strength. I thought I was strong, but I was a weak, scared man, and she’s the one who showed me what true bravery is.

Scarlett's been writing her book as well, and we share ideas, talking about what she wants to write about. She never fails to amaze me with her beautifully complex mind.

We sit in the garden, looking at the views and embracing our beautiful life as she lies with her head on my lap, typing away.

"How's it going," I ask her, mainly out of curiosity.

She doesn't respond. Instead, she keeps typing for a few more moments before pressing the last button, and then looking up at me.

She smiles, "It's done. It's complete."

I kiss her, gently caressing her face.

"We're complete."